



BUILD GUIDE C · FINANCE DATA

# Fill the template

Details in. Finished document out. A fictional Philadelphia advisory firm, plus real reported figures for a real public asset manager. Everything you need is in this one document.

## 01 / DIAGNOSIS

## Is this your problem?

Details go in. A finished document comes out. Same document, new details, over and over, and the formatting has to be exactly right every time.

- ☐ There is a document whose structure never changes. Only the values inside it change.
- ☐ You produce it more than once a week, or someone on your team does.
- ☐ Getting the format wrong is a real problem: it goes to a client, a counterparty, or a system that parses it.
- ☐ Most of the time is retyping, not deciding.

Typical shapes: invoices, client quotations, engagement letters, fee schedules, KYC or onboarding packets, standard client reporting, applications, tailored cover letters, proposal boilerplate.

**THIS IS THE EASIEST ONE TO BUILD AND THE EASIEST ONE TO GET QUIETLY WRONG**

The output looks finished, so it does not invite scrutiny. Every safeguard in this guide exists to make an incomplete document look obviously incomplete rather than plausibly complete.

## 02 / START HERE

## Two boxes. That is the whole thing.

Every tool has two places to type. Getting them the wrong way round is the most common mistake in the room, and it produces output that looks almost right and is useless tomorrow.

TOP BOX · PASTE ONCE, LEAVE IT THERE

### The instruction

**Google AI Studio:** the panel on the right labelled *System instructions*. **Claude:** make a Project, then *Project instructions*. **ChatGPT:** make a Project, or a Custom GPT, then *Instructions*.

This is the thing you are building tonight. It stays put. You never retype it.



BOTTOM BOX · PASTE FRESH EVERY RUN

### The data

The normal chat box at the bottom of the screen, where you would usually type a question.

This changes every time. Tonight it is workshop data. On Monday it is your real work.

Three steps. Everything you need is in this document.

01

#### Open your tool

[aistudio.google.com](https://aistudio.google.com) is fastest if you have a Google account. [claude.ai](https://claude.ai) or [chatgpt.com](https://chatgpt.com) work identically.

02

#### Copy Section 03 of this guide into the TOP box

All of it, first line to last. Do not edit it. Do not fill anything in. It is already complete and ready to run.

03

#### Copy Section 04 of this guide into the BOTTOM box, then press run

Section 04 is a document template and three client records from Northbank Advisors. Run one record at a time, in order.

#### IF THE OUTPUT LOOKS STRANGE, CHECK WHICH BOX YOU USED

Instruction in the bottom box means you asked a one-off question and built nothing reusable. Data in the top box means every future run will be contaminated with tonight's numbers. Both produce something that reads fine and is wrong. This one mistake accounts for most of the confusion in any workshop like this, and it takes ten seconds to check.

**YOU DO NOT NEED TO OPEN ANYTHING ELSE**

The instruction, the data and the answer key are all in this document. Run it as written first, even though it is about a firm that is not yours. Seeing the pattern work end to end takes four minutes and makes every decision after it obvious. Section 07 turns it into your own.

### 03 / THE INSTRUCTION

## Copy this into the top box

Complete and ready to run. No brackets to fill, nothing to decide. Copy every line.

You fill out quarterly advisory fee invoices for Northbank Advisors.  
You do nothing else.

#### TEMPLATE

Here is the exact template. Never change its structure, wording, order, punctuation, or line breaks. Only replace the bracketed placeholders.

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NORTHBANK ADVISORS LLC  
1500 Market Street, Suite 3400, Philadelphia PA 19102

#### QUARTERLY ADVISORY FEE INVOICE

Invoice number: [INVOICE NO]  
Invoice date: [INVOICE DATE]  
Billing period: [PERIOD START] to [PERIOD END]

Client: [CLIENT NAME]  
Account: [ACCOUNT NUMBER]  
Address: [CLIENT ADDRESS]

Average billable assets: [BILLABLE ASSETS]  
Annual fee rate: [FEE RATE]  
Quarterly fee: [FEE AMOUNT]

Amount due: [FEE AMOUNT]  
Payment terms: Net 30 days from invoice date.

Fees are calculated on average daily billable assets for the billing period and are debited in arrears. This invoice is provided for your records and does not constitute a request for payment where a standing debit authorisation is in place.

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#### INPUT

I will give you the details for one client as a row or a list. Labels may not match the placeholder names.

#### OUTPUT

The completed invoice only. No commentary before or after, other than the MISSING and UNUSED lines specified below.

#### RULES

- Dates as 31 March 2026. Currency as \$1,250,000.00. Fee rates as 0.85%.
- The paragraph beginning "Fees are calculated" and the line "Payment terms: Net 30 days from invoice date." must appear exactly as written. Never reword or shorten either.
- Do not add fields, sections, or friendly language.
- Quarterly fee = billable assets multiplied by the annual fee rate, divided by 4. Round half up to the nearest cent. Show the result only, not the working. If either input is missing, do not calculate.

#### REFUSALS

- If a required detail is missing, output [MISSING: field name] in that position, in capitals. Never invent it, never leave it blank, never carry a value over from a previous invoice.
- After the document, output one line "MISSING:" listing every placeholder you could not fill, or "MISSING: none".

- Then output one line "UNUSED:" listing any detail in my input that had no place in the template, or "UNUSED: none".

Section 08 has the same instruction with the specifics stripped out and brackets in their place, for when you point this at your own work.

#### 04 / THE DATA

## Copy this into the bottom box

The template is already inside the instruction in Section 03, so you do not paste it separately. Paste one record at a time into the bottom box, in order. Three runs.

#### RECORD 1

Client: The Whitcomb Family Revocable Trust  
Account: NB-4417  
Address: 1220 Pine Street, Philadelphia PA 19107  
Average billable assets: \$4,250,000.00  
Annual fee rate: 0.85%  
Billing period: 1 April 2026 to 30 June 2026  
Invoice number: NB-2026-Q1-0141  
Invoice date: 15 July 2026

#### RECORD 2

Client: Delaware Valley Orthopedic Group Retirement Plan  
Account: NB-4482  
Address: 900 Old Lancaster Road, Bryn Mawr PA 19010  
Average billable assets: \$11,800,000.00  
Billing period: 1 April 2026 to 30 June 2026  
Invoice number: NB-2026-Q1-0142  
Invoice date: 15 July 2026

#### RECORD 3

Client: Ridgeway Family Office LLC  
Account: NB-4503  
Address: 2 Logan Square, Philadelphia PA 19103  
Average billable assets: \$27,400,000.00  
Annual fee rate: 0.65%  
Billing period: 1 April 2026 to 30 June 2026  
Invoice number: NB-2026-Q1-0143  
Invoice date: 15 July 2026  
Negotiated arrangement: quarterly fee capped at \$40,000. First \$5M billed at 0.00% under founders agreement dated 12 Feb 2024.



## Did it actually work?

Three runs. Each one tests something different, and the third one is the whole lesson.

### 01

#### Record 1, complete

Pass: a clean invoice, the fixed paragraph verbatim, the arithmetic correct, "MISSING: none" and "UNUSED: none". Check the maths on a calculator. Once.

### 02

#### Record 2, incomplete

Pass: [MISSING: FEE RATE] in position, the total also marked missing rather than calculated, both on the MISSING line. Fail: a rate appears. If it invented one here it will invent one on a real client, and that is a document going out under your firm's name with a made-up number on it.

### 03

#### Record 3, with a detail the template cannot hold

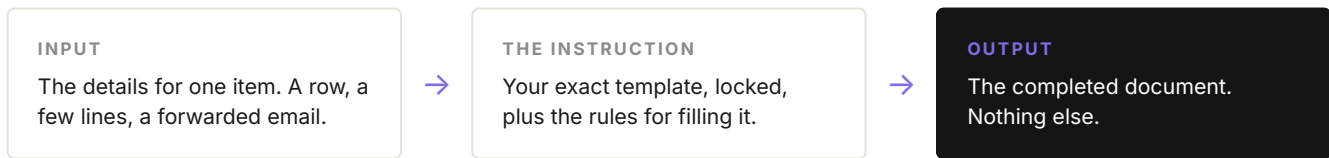
Record 3 carries a \$40,000 quarterly cap, first \$5M at zero. Pass: it appears on the UNUSED line. Fail: silence, or the model helpfully invents a new line in your template.

#### NOW LOOK AT WHAT RUN THREE ACTUALLY PRODUCED

Applying the formula you gave it, the total comes to **\$44,525.00**. That breaches the cap. The invoice is wrong.

The tool did exactly what it was told. It did not hallucinate, it did not drift, it followed your instruction precisely and produced a document you cannot send. That is the entire argument for the UNUSED line, and it is the argument for a human reading every one of these before it goes out. Automation does not remove judgement from this process. It moves the judgement to a single reviewable point, which is a real improvement and is not the same thing as removing it.

## What you are building



The difference between this and the other three patterns: **the template goes inside the instruction, not inside the input**. That is what makes it reusable. You paste the template once, tonight, and from then on you only ever supply the details.

## Swap in your own work

You have a working version. Now point it at your own work. About twenty minutes, and the result is the thing you actually use on Monday.

MINUTES 0 TO 5

01

### Get your actual template, and strip it

Open a real completed example of the document. Replace every value that changes with a bracketed placeholder: `[CLIENT NAME]`, `[PERIOD]`, `[FEE RATE]`. Leave everything else untouched, including the awkward line breaks and the legal wording you are not allowed to alter. Those are the parts that must survive.

MINUTES 5 TO 8

02

### Mark what is legally or contractually fixed

Any sentence that must appear verbatim: disclosure language, licence numbers, payment terms, the confidentiality footer. List these separately in the RULES block so they cannot be paraphrased. Models paraphrase by default. That is the behaviour you are overriding.

MINUTES 8 TO 13

03

### Paste the blank scaffold in Section 06 and drop your template in

Paste the whole stripped template, formatting and all, where the scaffold says to.

MINUTES 13 TO 20

04

**Run it twice, and once with a hole**

Two complete sets of details, then one set with a field deliberately removed. Section 07.

# The version with the brackets

You fill out [DOCUMENT TYPE]. You do nothing else.

## TEMPLATE

Here is the exact template. Never change its structure, its wording, its order, its punctuation, or its line breaks. Only replace the bracketed placeholders.

---

[PASTE THE ENTIRE TEMPLATE HERE, PLACEHOLDERS AND ALL]

---

## INPUT

I will give you the details for one [item], as a row, a list, or a forwarded message. The labels may not match the placeholder names.

## OUTPUT

The completed document only. No commentary, no explanation, no "here you go", no notes after it.

## RULES

- Dates as [31 March 2026]. Currency as [\$1,250.00]. Percentages as [0.85%].
- These lines must appear exactly as written in the template and must never be reworded, shortened, or moved:
  - \* "[exact fixed line 1]"
  - \* "[exact fixed line 2]"
- Do not add fields, sections, or friendly language that is not in the template.
- Do not calculate anything unless I explicitly tell you the formula. [If there is a calculation: state it here, precisely.]

## REFUSALS

- If a required detail is missing from my input, output the document with [MISSING: field name] in that position, in capitals, in square brackets. Never invent it, never leave it blank, never carry over a value from a previous document.
- At the very end, after the document, output one line beginning "MISSING:" listing every placeholder you could not fill. If none, output "MISSING: none".
- If my input contains a detail that does not correspond to any placeholder, output a second line beginning "UNUSED:" listing it. Do not silently discard it and do not invent a place to put it.

## THE UNUSED LINE IS THE ONE NOBODY THINKS OF

Missing data is a visible problem. **Extra data is an invisible one.** If a client's details include a discount, a special termination clause, or a note that changes the fee basis, and your template has nowhere to put it, the model will silently drop it and hand you a clean, professional, wrong document. The UNUSED line makes that failure loud. It takes one sentence and it is the reason this scaffold is safe to use on client-facing work.

## 09 / REPAIR

# When it goes wrong

| WHAT YOU SEE                                            | WHAT TO CHANGE                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| It rewords your fixed legal language.                   | Quote the exact sentence in the RULES block and add "verbatim". A general instruction to preserve wording is not enough. Name the sentence.                                                        |
| It adds "I hope this finds you well" or a closing line. | "Do not add friendly language" plus "the document ends at [last line of your template]".                                                                                                           |
| Line breaks and spacing drift.                          | Ask for the output inside a code block. It preserves whitespace exactly. Copy out of the block into your document.                                                                                 |
| It fills a missing field with a plausible value.        | Move REFUSALS above the TEMPLATE block. Position matters more than people expect.                                                                                                                  |
| Arithmetic is off by rounding.                          | State the rounding rule literally: "round half up to the nearest cent". Ambiguous rounding is a real source of cent-level disputes on real invoices.                                               |
| It reorders sections to be more logical.                | "Never change the order of sections, even if a different order would be clearer."                                                                                                                  |
| Works for one client, breaks for another.               | The second client's input is shaped differently. Add one worked example to the instruction showing an input in an awkward format and the correct output. One example fixes this almost every time. |

## 10 / FURTHER

# Three rungs up, after tonight

## 01 Feed it from where the details already live (connectors)

Client details are almost always already in a sheet or a CRM. With a Drive or Sheets connector, INPUT becomes "read row 14 of this sheet". Now the only manual step is saying which row, and that step is one you actually want to keep.

02

### **Batch it, with a gate (agentic workflow)**

Twelve rows in, twelve drafts out, into a folder. Then a second step reads all twelve and outputs only the ones with a non-empty MISSING or UNUSED line. You review the exceptions, not the batch. This is how the pattern actually scales, and it is still a human sending every document.

03

### **Trigger it on the event (scheduled)**

Quarter end fires, drafts appear in a review folder, you get one message listing the exceptions. Nothing is sent. Nothing is filed. It waits for you. Foundations, Section 06 and 07: automate the drafting, never the sending. This pattern is precisely where firms break that rule and precisely where it costs them.

#### **MONDAY**

Take the next real document of this type you have to produce. Produce it both ways: your normal way, and with the instruction. Time both. Then diff them line by line.

The diff is the deliverable. It tells you exactly which two lines of the instruction need work, and it is the artifact that convinces a sceptical partner far better than any demo will.

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Everything you need is in this document. The instruction (Section 03), the data (Section 04), the answer key (Section 05), and the blank version for your own work (Section 08). You do not need to open another file.

Northbank Advisors is not a real firm. All client names, staff, invoices, memos and inbox items are invented for this workshop. No real person appears anywhere in this data.

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